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Android Tablets Test

HOW WE TESTED

Android tablets have been around for quite some time now and only in the past year have we started seeing devices that are worth purchasing especially in the budget segment. A tablet today is essentially used for a few primary functions including web browsing, watching movies and videos, playing games, running utility apps and the occasional spreadsheet and document typing/editing, with some social networking thrown into the mix. To ensure that a tablet can perform these tasks well, we used a series of subjective and objective tests to measure their performance.

Benchmarks: The objective tests are a series of benchmarks that measure the performance of the hardware powering the tablets. These benchmarks are Quadrant, Antutu, and SmartBench. These benchmarks give an objective score that judges the performance of the hardware of the tablets. They give us an objective idea of how the tablets will perform when used for productivity and multitasking. There is also a test that measures the efficiency of the preloaded browser on the device called Rightware Browsermark. This test essentially tells us how the browser will perform especially if you are one who likes to browse heavy-duty websites.

The above-mentioned benchmarks give out a score (higher is better) and objectively measure the performance of the hardware.

Gaming: One of the biggest uses of a tablet today is to play games on the go. Some of the games that are available for tablets are graphically heavy and need some power to run smoothly. As a standard, we played quite a bit of Dead Trigger, Angry Birds Star Wars and Temple Run 2. These are some of the most popular games on the Google Play store and represent elements from the graphically heavy (Dead Trigger) to the average everyday games (Temple Run 2). While playing these games, we look out for issues such as screen lag, input lag, judder etc. There are also benchmarks, 3D Mark and GFX Bench (Egypt HD) that measures the gaming capabilities of the tablet. In all these cases, a higher score means better performance.

The above-mentioned benchmarks are available on the Android platform through the Google Play Store for free.

Start up: Beyond benchmarks (going subjective now), we also tested the start-up time of these devices to see how long it takes for the tablets to reach the lock screen from the power off mode. This was done after factory resetting the tablets, doing the logins at the first start-up, and restarting the device again. No apps were installed prior to this test, except for the ones that came preloaded.

Multimedia: Since today's tablets offer multimedia capabilities, we ran a bunch of videos on

the tablet. We tested the devices with all the popular formats (MP4, MKV and AVI). The videos included SD as well as HD content. We judged the ability of the device to play the video formats smoothly – jumping forwards and backward on the play-timeline to check for stutters, freeze, crashes etc. The quality and experience offered by the display was taken into account as well – viewing angles, colour reproduction, crispness, brightness etc. We also played a bunch of MP3 songs to see how the speakers performed.

Build: Since a tablet is considered as a "life-style" device, we have also taken into consideration the build quality, plastics used, slimness of the device and its overall feel in our hands. There are multiple parameters on which each tablet is rated, before we reach one final build quality score.

Battery life: What good is a tablet if its battery drains in a couple of minutes, right? Well, to test the longevity of the battery on the tablet, we ran a video in loop to see how long it lasts. The battery was charged to 100%. We ran an MP4 1080p movie on loop with the brightness and audio at maximum. The amount of time taken by the device to reach 0% battery level is determined as the battery life. Please note that if you use the device more conservatively (switch off location services, reduce the brightness and volume, etc.), it will last longer.

You can also do some productivity work such as documents, spreadsheets and more. You also have access to utility apps, some of which are customized based on your profession such as photo editing, architecture, medical apps and more. Finally, the most important utility factor of a tablet is that it should have a crisp display for consuming all the content as well as a good touch interface so that you can interact with the device with absolute ease. Not to mention a battery life that has the ability to last for more than a few minutes.

Based on these consumer parameters, we at Digit tested 30 tablets available to the consumers today ranging from the

cheapest to the most expensive. All these devices run on Android. Here is an in-depth look at how these tablets perform for consumers in everyday use.

DESIGN AND BUILD

You get what you pay for. That is the general correlation between the price of a tablet and the quality of its build. The plastics used, flex in the display, looks, flashy design and more get better with a higher price tag. This is the general norm and not a rule written in stone. In our comparison test we have seen the Nexus 7 (which is a brilliant performing device), show off a back panel, which is very plastic-y in its nature, and we wish

it were better. The same can be said about the Samsung Galaxy Note 800 – good-looking device with a cheap plastic back finish.

We also have the ASUS FonePad, a ₹16k tablet built very well. The rear has a plastic panel with a gunmetal finish giving it the feel of a premium tablet. The enclosure, which houses the SIM card and the microSD card, too is very well built.

We have seen some budget devices too surprise us with its build quality. These include the Lava E-Tab Xtron, Acer Icona B1, Zync Quad 8 and the iBall Slide Edu. Despite being budget devices, these tablets have impressed us with their build quality and have tried to stand

out from other competing tablets in the same price range. We also have the WickedLeak Wammy Desire II (yes, that really is the name) that looks like a Samsung Galaxy SIII on steroids.

Seven inches seems to be the sweet spot for the tablets as majority of the tablets present in our shootout boast of this form factor. We have the occasional 8- and 10-inch tablets too but everyone seems to be gunning for the most portable form factor. The advantage of the compact form is that the tablet is easier to carry and 7-inches though large is still a lot more convenient to hold up against one's ear when compared to a 10-inch device for making calls.